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Swadesh list

A **Swadesh list** (/ˈswɑːdɛʃ/) is a compilation of tentatively universal concepts for the purposes of lexicostatistics. That is, a Swadesh list is a list of forms and concepts which all languages, without exception, have terms for, such as star, hand, water, kill, sleep, and so forth. The number of such terms is small – a few hundred at most, or possibly less than a hundred. The inclusion or exclusion of many terms is subject to debate among linguists; thus, there are several different lists, and some authors may refer to "Swadesh lists." The Swadesh list is named after linguist Morris Swadesh.

Translations of a Swadesh list into a set of languages allow for researchers to quantify the interrelatedness of those languages. Swadesh lists are used in lexicostatistics (the quantitative assessment of the genealogical relatedness of languages) and glottochronology (the dating of language divergence). For instance, the terms on a Swadesh list can be compared between two languages (since both languages will have them) to see if they are related and how closely, thus giving useful information that can be further applied to comparison of the languages. (Actual lexicostatistics is quite complicated, and usually sets of languages are compared.)

Versions and authors

Morris Swadesh created several versions of his list. He started^[1] with a list of 215 meanings (falsely introduced as a list of 225 meanings in the paper due to a spelling error^[2]), which he reduced to 165 words for the Salish-Spokane-Kalispel language. In 1952, he published a list of 215 meanings,^[3] of which he suggested the removal of 16 for being unclear or not universal, with one added to arrive at 200 words. In 1955,^[4] he wrote, "The only solution appears to be a drastic weeding out of the list, in the realization that quality is at least as important as quantity. Even the new list has defects, but they are relatively mild and few in number." After minor corrections, the final 100-word list was published posthumously in 1971^[5] and 1972.

Other versions of lexicostatistical test lists were published e.g. by Robert Lees (1953), John A. Holm (1958:145f), Dell Hymes (1960:6), E. Cross (1964 with 241 concepts), W. J. Samarin (1967:22), D. Wilson (1969 with 57 meanings), Lionel Bender (1969), R. L. Oswald (1971), Winfred P. Lehmann (1984:35f), D. Ringe (1992, *passim*, different versions), Sergei Starostin (1984, *passim*, different versions), William S-Y. Wang (1994), M. Lohr (2000, 128 meanings in 18 languages). B. Kessler (2002), and many others. The Concepticon,^[6] a project hosted at the Cross-Linguistic Linked Data (CLLD) project, collects various concept lists (including classical Swadesh lists) across different linguistic areas and times, currently listing 240 different concept lists.^[7]

Frequently used and widely available on the internet, is the version by Isidore Dyen (1992, 200 meanings of 95 language variants). Since 2010, a team around Michael Dunn has tried to update and enhance that list.^[8]

Principle

In origin, the words in the Swadesh lists were chosen for their universal, culturally independent availability in as many languages as possible, regardless of their stability (how prone the word is to changing, as all words do over time to a greater or lesser extent, which can include borrowing from another language).

However, stability may be important. The stability of terms on a Swadesh list under language change and the potential use of this fact for purposes of glottochronology (study of how languages develop and branch apart over time) have been analyzed by numerous authors, including Marisa Lohr 1999, 2000.^[9]

The Swadesh list was put together by Morris Swadesh on the basis of his intuition. Similar more recent lists, such as the Dolgopolsky list (1964) or the Leipzig–Jakarta list (2009), are based on systematic data from many different languages, but they are not yet as widely known nor as widely used as the Swadesh list.

Usage in lexicostatistics and glottochronology

Lexicostatistical test lists are used in lexicostatistics to define subgroupings of languages, and in glottochronology to "provide dates for branching points in the tree."^[10] The task of defining (and counting the number) of cognate words in the list is far from trivial, and often is subject to dispute, because cognates do not necessarily look similar, and recognition of cognates presupposes knowledge of the sound laws of the respective languages.

Swadesh 100 original final list

Swadesh's final list, published in 1971,^[5] contains 100 terms. Explanations of the terms can be found in Swadesh 1952^[3] or, where noted by a dagger (†), in Swadesh 1955. Note that only this original sequence clarifies the correct meaning which is lost in an alphabetical order, e.g., in the case "27. bark" (originally without the specification here added).

- | | |
|---|--------------------------------------|
| 1. <u>I</u> (first person singular pronoun) | 10. <u>many</u> |
| 2. <u>you</u> (second person singular pronoun; 1952
thou & ye) | 11. <u>one</u> |
| 3. <u>we</u> (1955: <u>inclusive</u>) | 12. <u>two</u> |
| 4. <u>this</u> | 13. <u>big</u> |
| 5. <u>that</u> | 14. <u>long</u> (not wide) |
| 6. <u>who?</u> ("?" not 1971) | 15. <u>small</u> |
| 7. <u>what?</u> ("?" not 1971) | 16. <u>woman</u> |
| 8. <u>not</u> | 17. <u>man</u> (adult male human) |
| 9. <u>all</u> (of a number) | 18. <u>person</u> (individual human) |
| | 19. <u>fish</u> (noun) |

20. bird
21. dog
22. louse
23. tree (not log)
24. seed (noun)
25. leaf (botanics)
26. root (botanics)
27. bark (of tree)
28. skin (1952: person's)
29. flesh (1952 meat, flesh)
30. blood
31. bone
32. grease (1952: fat, organic substance)
33. egg
34. horn (of bull etc., not 1952)[†]
35. tail
36. feather (large, not down)
37. hair (on head of humans)
38. head (anatomic)
39. ear
40. eye
41. nose
42. mouth
43. tooth (front, rather than molar)
44. tongue (anatomical)
45. claw (not in 1952)^{†1}
46. foot (not leg)
47. knee (not 1952)[†]
48. hand
49. belly (lower part of body, abdomen)
50. neck (not nape)
51. breast
52. heart
53. liver
54. drink (verb)
55. eat (verb)
56. bite (verb)
57. see (verb)
58. hear (verb)
59. know (facts)
60. sleep (verb)

61. die (verb)
62. kill (verb)
63. swim (verb)
64. fly (verb)
65. walk (verb)
66. come (verb)
67. lie (on side, recline)
68. sit (verb)
69. stand (verb)
70. give (verb)
71. say (verb)[†]
72. sun
73. moon (not 1952)[†]
74. star
75. water (noun)
76. rain (noun, 1952 verb)
77. stone
78. sand
79. earth (soil)
80. cloud (not fog)
81. smoke (noun, of fire)
82. fire
83. ash(es)
84. burn (verb intransitive)
85. path (1952 road, trail; not street)
86. mountain (not hill)
87. red (color)
88. green (color)
89. yellow (color)
90. white (color)
91. black (color)
92. night
93. hot (adjective; 1952 warm, of weather)
94. cold (of weather)
95. full[†]
96. new
97. good
98. round (not 1952)[†]
99. dry (substance)
100. name

^ "Claw" was only added in 1955, but again replaced by many well-known specialists with (finger)nail, because expressions for "claw" are not available in many old, extinct, or lesser known languages.

The 110-item Global Lexicostatistical Database list uses the original 100-item Swadesh list, in addition to 10 other words from the Swadesh–Yakhontov list.^[11]

Swadesh 207 list

The most used list nowadays is the Swadesh 207-word list, adapted from Swadesh 1952.^[3]

In Wiktionary ("Swadesh lists by language"), Panlex^{[12][13]} and in Palisto's "Swadesh Word List of Indo-European languages",^[14] hundreds of Swadesh lists in this form can be found.

- | | |
|-------------------|-----------------------|
| 1. I | 30. thick |
| 2. you (singular) | 31. heavy |
| 3. he | 32. small |
| 4. we | 33. short |
| 5. you (plural) | 34. narrow |
| 6. they | 35. thin |
| 7. this | 36. woman |
| 8. that | 37. man (adult male) |
| 9. here | 38. man (human being) |
| 10. there | 39. child |
| 11. who | 40. wife |
| 12. what | 41. husband |
| 13. where | 42. mother |
| 14. when | 43. father |
| 15. how | 44. animal |
| 16. not | 45. fish |
| 17. all | 46. bird |
| 18. many | 47. dog |
| 19. some | 48. louse |
| 20. few | 49. snake |
| 21. other | 50. worm |
| 22. one | 51. tree |
| 23. two | 52. forest |
| 24. three | 53. stick |
| 25. four | 54. fruit |
| 26. five | 55. seed |
| 27. big | 56. leaf |
| 28. long | 57. root |
| 29. wide | 58. bark (of a tree) |

- | | |
|--------------------|-----------------------------|
| 59. flower | 102. to hear |
| 60. grass | 103. to know |
| 61. rope | 104. to think |
| 62. skin | 105. to smell |
| 63. meat | 106. to fear |
| 64. blood | 107. to sleep |
| 65. bone | 108. to live |
| 66. fat (noun) | 109. to die |
| 67. egg | 110. to kill |
| 68. horn | 111. to fight |
| 69. tail | 112. to hunt |
| 70. feather | 113. to hit |
| 71. hair | 114. to cut |
| 72. head | 115. to split |
| 73. ear | 116. to stab |
| 74. eye | 117. to scratch |
| 75. nose | 118. to dig |
| 76. mouth | 119. to swim |
| 77. tooth | 120. to fly |
| 78. tongue (organ) | 121. to walk |
| 79. fingernail | 122. to come |
| 80. foot | 123. to lie (as in a bed) |
| 81. leg | 124. to sit |
| 82. knee | 125. to stand |
| 83. hand | 126. to turn (intransitive) |
| 84. wing | 127. to fall |
| 85. belly | 128. to give |
| 86. guts | 129. to hold |
| 87. neck | 130. to squeeze |
| 88. back | 131. to rub |
| 89. breast | 132. to wash |
| 90. heart | 133. to wipe |
| 91. liver | 134. to pull |
| 92. to drink | 135. to push |
| 93. to eat | 136. to throw |
| 94. to bite | 137. to tie |
| 95. to suck | 138. to sew |
| 96. to spit | 139. to count |
| 97. to vomit | 140. to say |
| 98. to blow | 141. to sing |
| 99. to breathe | 142. to play |
| 100. to laugh | 143. to float |
| 101. to see | 144. to flow |

145. to freeze
 146. to swell
 147. sun
 148. moon
 149. star
 150. water
 151. rain
 152. river
 153. lake
 154. sea
 155. salt
 156. stone
 157. sand
 158. dust
 159. earth
 160. cloud
 161. fog
 162. sky
 163. wind
 164. snow
 165. ice
 166. smoke
 167. fire
 168. ash
 169. to burn
 170. road
 171. mountain
 172. red
 173. green
 174. yellow
 175. white
 176. black

177. night
 178. day
 179. year
 180. warm
 181. cold
 182. full
 183. new
 184. old
 185. good
 186. bad
 187. rotten
 188. dirty
 189. straight
 190. round
 191. sharp (as a knife)
 192. dull (as a knife)
 193. smooth
 194. wet
 195. dry
 196. correct
 197. near
 198. far
 199. right
 200. left
 201. at
 202. in
 203. with
 204. and
 205. if
 206. because
 207. name

Shorter lists

The **Swadesh–Yakhontov list** is a 35-word subset of the Swadesh list posited as especially stable by Russian linguist Sergei Yakhontov around the 1960s, although the list was only officially published in 1991.^[15] It has been used in lexicostatistics by linguists such as Sergei Starostin. With their Swadesh numbers, they are:^[16]

- | | |
|-------------------|----------|
| 1. I | 11. who |
| 2. you (singular) | 12. what |
| 7. this | 22. one |

23. two
45. fish
47. dog
48. louse
64. blood
65. bone
67. egg
68. horn
69. tail
73. ear
74. eye
75. nose
77. tooth
78. tongue
83. hand

103. know
109. die
128. give
147. sun
148. moon
150. water
155. salt
156. stone
163. wind
167. fire
179. year
182. full
183. new
207. name

Holman *et al.* (2008) found that in identifying the relationships between Chinese dialects the Swadesh–Yakhontov list was less accurate than the original Swadesh-100 list. Further they found that a different (40-word) list (also known as the ASJP list) was just as accurate as the Swadesh-100 list. However, they calculated the relative stability of the words by comparing retentions between languages in established language families. They found no statistically significant difference in the correlations in the families of the Old versus the New World.

The ranked Swadesh-100 list, with Swadesh numbers and relative stability, is as follows (Holman *et al.*, Appendix. Asterisked words appear on the 40-word list):

- | | |
|------------------------|-------------------------|
| 1. 22 *louse (42.8) | 19. 31 *bone (30.1) |
| 2. 12 *two (39.8) | 20. 44 *tongue (30.1) |
| 3. 75 *water (37.4) | 21. 28 *skin (29.6) |
| 4. 39 *ear (37.2) | 22. 92 *night (29.6) |
| 5. 61 *die (36.3) | 23. 25 *leaf (29.4) |
| 6. 1 *I (35.9) | 24. 76 rain (29.3) |
| 7. 53 *liver (35.7) | 25. 62 kill (29.2) |
| 8. 40 *eye (35.4) | 26. 30 *blood (29.0) |
| 9. 48 *hand (34.9) | 27. 34 *horn (28.8) |
| 10. 58 *hear (33.8) | 28. 18 *person (28.7) |
| 11. 23 *tree (33.6) | 29. 47 *knee (28.0) |
| 12. 19 *fish (33.4) | 30. 11 *one (27.4) |
| 13. 100 *name (32.4) | 31. 41 *nose (27.3) |
| 14. 77 *stone (32.1) | 32. 95 *full (26.9) |
| 15. 43 *tooth (30.7) | 33. 66 *come (26.8) |
| 16. 51 *breasts (30.7) | 34. 74 *star (26.6) |
| 17. 2 *you (30.6) | 35. 86 *mountain (26.2) |
| 18. 85 *path (30.2) | 36. 82 *fire (25.7) |

37. 3 *we (25.4)	69. 99 dry (18.9)
38. 54 *drink (25.0)	70. 37 hair (18.6)
39. 57 *see (24.7)	71. 81 smoke (18.5)
40. 27 bark (24.5)	72. 8 not (18.3)
41. 96 *new (24.3)	73. 4 this (18.2)
42. 21 *dog (24.2)	74. 24 seed (18.2)
43. 72 *sun (24.2)	75. 16 woman (17.9)
44. 64 fly (24.1)	76. 98 round (17.9)
45. 32 grease (23.4)	77. 14 long (17.4)
46. 73 moon (23.4)	78. 69 stand (17.1)
47. 70 give (23.3)	79. 97 good (16.9)
48. 52 heart (23.2)	80. 17 man (16.7)
49. 36 feather (23.1)	81. 94 cold (16.6)
50. 90 white (22.7)	82. 29 flesh (16.4)
51. 89 yellow (22.5)	83. 50 neck (16.0)
52. 20 bird (21.8)	84. 71 say (16.0)
53. 38 head (21.7)	85. 84 burn (15.5)
54. 79 earth (21.7)	86. 35 tail (14.9)
55. 46 foot (21.6)	87. 78 sand (14.9)
56. 91 black (21.6)	88. 5 that (14.7)
57. 42 mouth (21.5)	89. 65 walk (14.4)
58. 88 green (21.1)	90. 68 sit (14.3)
59. 60 sleep (21.0)	91. 10 many (14.2)
60. 7 what (20.7)	92. 9 all (14.1)
61. 26 root (20.5)	93. 59 know (14.1)
62. 45 claw (20.5)	94. 80 cloud (13.9)
63. 56 bite (20.5)	95. 63 swim (13.6)
64. 83 ash (20.3)	96. 49 belly (13.5)
65. 87 red (20.2)	97. 13 big (13.4)
66. 55 eat (20.0)	98. 93 hot (11.6)
67. 33 egg (19.8)	99. 67 lie (11.2)
68. 6 who (19.0)	100. 15 small (6.3)

Sign languages

In studying the sign languages of Vietnam and Thailand, linguist James Woodward noted that the traditional Swadesh list applied to spoken languages was unsuited for sign languages. The Swadesh list results in overestimation of the relationships between sign languages, due to indexical signs such as pronouns and parts of the body. The modified list is as follows, in mostly alphabetical order:^[17]

- | | |
|-----------|------------|
| 1. all | 3. bad |
| 2. animal | 4. because |

5. bird
6. black
7. blood
8. child
9. count
10. day
11. die
12. dirty
13. dog
14. dry
15. dull
16. dust
17. earth
18. egg
19. grease
20. father
21. feather
22. fire
23. fish
24. flower
25. good
26. grass
27. green
28. heavy
29. how
30. hunt
31. husband
32. ice
33. if
34. kill
35. laugh
36. leaf
37. lie
38. live
39. long
40. louse
41. man
42. meat
43. mother
44. mountain
45. name
46. narrow
47. new

48. night
49. not
50. old
51. other
52. person
53. play
54. rain
55. red
56. correct
57. river
58. rope
59. salt
60. sea
61. sharp
62. short
63. sing
64. sit
65. smooth
66. snake
67. snow
68. stand
69. star
70. stone
71. sun
72. tail
73. thin
74. tree
75. vomit
76. warm
77. water
78. wet
79. what
80. when
81. where
82. white
83. who
84. wide
85. wife
86. wind
87. with
88. woman
89. wood
90. worm

91. year
 92. yellow
 93. full
 94. moon
 95. brother

96. cat
 97. dance
 98. pig
 99. sister
 100. work

See also

■ Other lists

- [A General Service List of English Words](#) — roughly 2,000 of the most common English words
- [Dolgopolsky list](#) — the 15 words that change least as languages evolve
- [Leipzig–Jakarta list](#) — 100 words resistant to borrowing, used to estimate chronological separation of languages, intended to improve on the Swadesh list
- Wiktionary listings:
 - [wikt:Appendix:Swadesh lists](#)
 - [wikt:Category:Swadesh lists by language](#)

■ Projects and databases

- [Automated Similarity Judgment Program](#) — a project applying computational approaches to comparative linguistics using a database of word lists
- [Evolution of Human Languages](#) — a project to provide a genealogical classification of the world's languages
- [Intercontinental Dictionary Series](#) — a database of vocabulary lists in over 200 languages, especially indigenous South American and Northeast Caucasian

■ Linguistic concepts and fields

- [Cognate](#) — a word derived from the same word as another
- [Historical linguistics](#) — the study of language change over time
- [Indo-European studies](#) — the study of Indo-European languages and their hypothetical common ancestor, Proto-Indo-European
- [Proto-language](#) — a postulated ancestral language from which a family of languages is presumed to have evolved

■ Methods of language reconstruction

- [Comparative method](#) — feature-by-feature comparison of related languages to reconstruct their development and common ancestor
- [Mass lexical comparison](#) — a controversial method, seen as a rival to the comparative method, to determine the relatedness of languages
- [Internal reconstruction](#) — reconstruction of an earlier state of a language without comparing it to other languages

■ Other

- [Basic English](#) — a simplified form of English for communication and learning

Notes

1. Swadesh 1950: 161
2. List, J.-M. (2018): Towards a history of concept list compilation in historical linguistics. *History and Philosophy of the Language Sciences* 5.10. URL (<https://www.nature.com/articles/sdata2018205>)
3. Swadesh 1952: 456–7 PDF (<https://cdstar.shh.mpg.de/bitstreams/EAEA0-BF5B-6FD1-C12C-0/Swadesh1952.pdf>)
4. Swadesh 1955: 125
5. Swadesh 1971: 283
6. Concepticon (<http://concepticon.clld.org/>). doi:10.5281/zenodo.19782 (<https://doi.org/10.5281%2Fzenodo.19782>)
7. List, J.-M., M. Cysouw, and R. Forkel (2016): Concepticon. A resource for the linking of concept lists. In: *Proceedings of the Tenth International Conference on Language Resources and Evaluation*. 2393-2400. PDF (http://www.lrec-conf.org/proceedings/lrec2016/pdf/127_Paper.pdf)
8. "IELex :: IELex" (<https://github.com/evotext/ielex-data-and-tree>). *GitHub*. March 2022.
9. Marisa Lohr (2000), "New Approaches to Lexicostatistics and Glottochronology" in C. Renfrew, A. McMahon and L. Trask, ed. *Time Depth in Historical Linguistics*, Vol. 1, pp. 209–223
10. Sheila Embleton (1992), in W. Bright, ed., *International Encyclopaedia of Linguistics*, Oxford University Press, p. 131
11. Starostin, George (ed.) 2011-2019. *The Global Lexicostatistical Database* (<http://starling.rinet.ru/new100/>). Moscow: Higher School of Economics, & Santa Fe: Santa Fe Institute. Accessed on 2020-12-26.
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13. David Kamholz, Jonathan Pool, Susan Colowick (2014), *PanLex: Building a Resource for Panlingual Lexical Translation* PDF (http://www.lrec-conf.org/proceedings/lrec2014/pdf/1029_Paper.pdf)
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15. Concept list Yakhontov 1991 100 (<https://concepticon.clld.org/contributions/Yakhontov-1991-100>). *Concepticon*. Accessed 2020-12-30.
16. Starostin 1991
17. Karen Emmorey; Harlan L. Lane (2000). *The Signs of Language Revisited: An Anthology to Honor Ursula Bellugi and Edward Klima* (<https://books.google.com/books?id=Zqq2PUsAGuIC&pg=PA20>). Psychology Press. pp. 20–21. ISBN 978-0-8058-3246-4. Retrieved 26 September 2011.

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External links

- Lexico-semantic universals: A critical overview (<http://www.deepdyve.com/lp/de-gruyter/lexico-semantic-universals-a-critical-overview-YJqNg4PDlr>)
- Rosetta project (<https://web.archive.org/web/20150623030728/http://rosettaproject.org/>)
- Swadesh Lists of Brazilian Native Languages (<https://web.archive.org/web/20171111012059/http://www2.unucseh.ueg.br/gicli/ListasEnglish.htm>)
- Illustrated linguistic and etymology blog by Stephan Steinbach (<https://alternativetransport.wordpress.com/category/linguistics/>)

Retrieved from "https://en.wikipedia.org/w/index.php?title=Swadesh_list&oldid=1293077587"